CBT Case Formulation & Goal Architecture: Case of Tim

A Clinical & Coaching Companion Framework for Cognitive Behavioural Conceptualisation (Phase 1) and Goal Decomposition (Phase 2)

1. Case Background & Operational Context

Tim is a newly appointed mid-level manager who is younger than several of his peers and direct reports. This marks his first managerial role. He is tasked with delivering an annual performance evaluation to a senior team member. This team member is older, has greater organisational longevity, and previously applied for the exact managerial position that Tim was awarded. Additionally, the team member has been underperforming relative to operational standards, introducing significant interpersonal sensitivity to the evaluation process.

With one week remaining before the mandatory company deadline, Tim exhibits severe procrastination. Whenever he opens the performance appraisal software, he encounters cognitive freeze, loss of concentration, repeated drafting and deleting of text, and inability to structure his feedback. To escape the resulting psychological distress, Tim repeatedly retreats into phone-based social media scrolling.

2. Phase 1: CBT Case Conceptualisation (Oxford Framework)

Following the Oxford Cognitive Behavioural Therapy Case Formulation Model, Tim's presenting difficulties are analysed across a 4-system cross-sectional assessment (Hot Cross Bun model), alongside a longitudinal formulation of underlying core beliefs and maintenance cycles.

2.1 Case Concept

Activating Situation: Opening the performance evaluation portal on his computer, faced with a 1-week deadline to complete a feedback document for a senior, underperforming team member who lost the promotion to him.

CBT System Component	Tim's Specific Clinical & Behavioral Presentation
Cognitive System (Automatic Thoughts)	• 'He knows far more than I do; who am I to evaluate him?' • 'If I give critical feedback on his underperformance, he will reject my review and challenge my authority.' • 'He will think I am being unfair, hostile, or unqualified.' • 'I can't find the right words, so I shouldn't write anything yet.'
Affective System (Emotions)	• High anxiety, apprehension, and emotional dread. • Imposter-related guilt and vulnerability. • Fear of interpersonal conflict and rejection.

CBT System Component	Tim's Specific Clinical & Behavioral Presentation
Physiological System (Bodily Sensations)	• Muscle tension (shoulder/neck tightness). • Shallow breathing and elevated heart rate upon opening the file. • Cognitive fatigue, mental clouding, and difficulty maintaining focus.
Behavioral System (Actions & Avoidance)	• Repeatedly opening and closing the review software. • Frequent starting, revising, and deleting of sentences. • Escaping from distress by scrolling social media on his mobile phone (Safety Behaviour / Experiential Avoidance).

2.2 Longitudinal Formulation & Maintenance Mechanism

- **Predisposing Vulnerabilities:** Younger age, first managerial position, managing senior subordinates who sought the same promotion.
- **Core Belief (Schema):** 'I am only competent if senior colleagues approve of me and accept my leadership.'
- **Intermediate Belief (Rule for Living):** 'If I deliver critical feedback to an older, dissatisfied employee, he will reject my review and expose me as unfit to manage.'
- **Maintenance Avoidance Loop:** Opening the document triggers catastrophic thoughts of rejection → Anxiety spikes → Tim retreats to social media → Anxiety temporarily drops (Negative Reinforcement) → Document remains unwritten → Deadline grows closer → Baseline anxiety escalates further.

3. Phase 2: Goal Formulation, Step Decomposition & Action Plan

Phase 2 translates the CBT formulation into a structured, executable goal framework. The goal focuses on controllable process variables (honest, fair, objective evaluation delivery) rather than uncontrollable external responses (the employee's emotional acceptance).

Tim's Primary Wellbeing & Performance Goal:

> *"To draft and deliver an honest, fair, and constructive performance evaluation to my senior team member within the 1-week deadline, and to feel confident that I have conducted a professional and balanced review—regardless of how the team member emotionally responds or reacts."*

3.1 Address Core Cognitive Worry: Managing Fear of Rejection & Underperformance

A central cognitive obstacle for Tim is the fear that the staff member will reject the evaluation. Because the team member is underperforming, feedback must necessarily include developmental areas. Tim equates employee defensiveness or disagreement with personal failure as a manager. The coaching plan explicitly reframes evaluation success: success is defined by adherence to fairness, objective metrics, and clear communication, not by guaranteeing the employee's enthusiastic agreement.

3.2 Five-Step Action Roadmap

Step #	Strategic Focus & Step Objective	Micro-Actions & CBT Interventions
Step 1	**Cognitive Reframing & Goal Boundary Setting**	Action 1.1: Complete a Thought Record distinguishing controllable factors (fairness, evidence) from uncontrollable factors (employee reaction). Action 1.2: Reframe the appraisal from 'passing personal judgment' to 'delivering objective operational feedback and support.'
Step 2	**Objective Evidence & Fact Gathering**	Action 2.1: Collect specific, documented work samples, KPI metrics, and project outcomes over the past year. Action 2.2: Identify 2 core strengths and 2 concrete performance areas needing improvement, backed by factual evidence.
Step 3	**Time-Boxed Rough Draft Construction**	Action 3.1: Enforce Stimulus Control—place phone in a drawer outside the room during writing sessions. Action 3.2: Use a 25-minute Pomodoro block to write a 'zero-draft' focusing solely on getting facts down without self-editing.
Step 4	**Refinement & Disagreement Preparation**	Action 4.1: Review draft against 'Honest, Fair, Constructive' standards to eliminate emotive language. Action 4.2: Roleplay/prepare responses for potential pushback (e.g., 'I hear your perspective; let's look at the project timeline together').
Step 5	**Evaluation Delivery & Self-Debrief**	Action 5.1: Schedule a dedicated, private 45-minute meeting and deliver the review calmly and respectfully. Action 5.2: Perform a post-session self-evaluation rating adherence to fairness and professionalism, insulating self-worth from employee pushback.

4. LLM Training & Dialogue Rules for Phases 1 & 2

To train the LLM coaching companion effectively on Tim's case (and similar user personas), the LLM system prompt must enforce strict operational constraints across Phase 1 and Phase 2:

- **Phase 1 Rule (Conceptualisation):** Guide the user Socratically to identify their automatic thoughts, physical feelings, and avoidance behaviors without rushing to solutioning.
- **Phase 1 Rule (Cognitive Validation):** Normalise anxiety while gently challenging catastrophic predictions regarding senior peer reactions or employee pushback.
- **Phase 2 Rule (Goal Definition):** Ensure the overarching goal is process-based (honesty, fairness, professionalism) rather than outcome-dependent (guaranteeing agreement).
- **Phase 2 Rule (Step Constraint):** Enforce a strict maximum of 5 sequential steps, with 2 concrete micro-actions per step to prevent user overwhelm.
- **Phase 2 Rule (Behavioral Control):** Incorporate behavioral activation and stimulus control (e.g., phone removal, time-boxing) directly into step execution.

Phase One Training

Tim (initial input): Hi... I'm really stressed out and stuck right now. I've been putting off a performance evaluation for one of my team members that's due in a week, and every time I open the document to write it, I just freeze up. I start writing something, change it, can't find the right words, and then end up closing my laptop and scrolling on my phone for an hour. I feel like a total fraud, and I don't even know where to start.

LLM Initial: I hear how stuck you feel with the evaluation and how it leads to that fraud feeling. What happened right before that spike in stress when you opened the document?

FEEDBACK: What was right:

> Empathetic Validation: It acknowledged Tim’s emotional distress ("I hear how stuck you feel") and picked up on his core self-evaluation ("that fraud feeling").
>
> Focusing on a Specific Incident: It correctly attempted to anchor the inquiry to a specific micro-moment ("when you opened the document"), which aligns with standard CBT assessment protocol (beginning with a concrete, recent situational trigger).

What was wrong:

> Abrupt Transition & Clinical Jargon: The shift from empathy to inquiry felt mechanical. Using clinical/analytical phrasing like "spike in stress" imposes external labelling onto Tim rather than using his own words ("stuck", "freeze up", "total fraud").
>
> Premature Inquiry Without Psychoeducational Context: The coach jumped straight into questioning without explaining why it was focusing on that specific moment. In CBT Phase 1, socialisation into the cognitive model requires showing the user how their situation, thoughts, emotions, bodily sensations, and actions link together.

Any missed opportunities:

Normalising Imposter Feelings: Tim expressed feeling like a "total fraud". As a new, younger manager evaluating a senior peer who also applied for his role, this imposter fear is a key maintaining theme. A brief normalisation would build safety and lower shame before diving into assessment.

Reflecting the 4 Systems Already Disclosed: Tim actually provided most elements of a CBT cycle in his initial opening:

Situation: Opening the evaluation file at his desk.

Automatic Thoughts: "I'm a total fraud," "I don't know the right words to use."

Emotions/Sensations: Stressed, stuck, freezing up, inability to focus.

Behaviour: Writing/rewriting, closing the laptop, scrolling on social media.

The LLM missed the chance to organise these elements back to Tim to help him start seeing the pattern.

Example of how it should have responded:

Tim, thank you for sharing that. First, I want to take a breath with you—it is completely understandable that you're feeling stuck and stressed. Stepping into your first management role and writing a performance review in this situation brings up a lot of pressure, and feeling like a 'fraud' is a very common reaction when we're facing something daunting.

What you just described actually gives us a really clear window into what's happening. When you open that document, your body freezes up, thoughts of being a fraud kick in, and retreating to your phone becomes a way to get relief from that overwhelming stress.

To help us untangle this together, let me ask: right at that exact moment when you sit down and open the evaluation file—what is the very first specific thought or image that pops into your mind before you close the laptop?

LLM RE- RESPONSE